

Those under Confederate control

The vast majority of Black people under Confederate control were enslaved, and remained on plantations or farms until they were liberated by U.S. troops. Most enlisted men did not take enslaved workers with them to war, but a sizeable percentage of officers did, though this declined as the war dragged on. As an institution, enslavement was irrevocably weakened after the Emancipation Proclamation, and by the last year of the war, many enslaved people—even those in unconquered areas of the South—refused to work, or had no incentive to do so, as the majority of white men had left their homes and farms. White female or Black drivers, increasingly common by 1864, could not maintain discipline over enslaved workers, and as slavery began to die so, too, did the remaining economic power of the Confederacy.

200,000 The number of Black Americans who fought for their freedom in either the Army or Navy. About one-third of them died.



Freedom seekers

Black American refugees drive their wagon across the Rappahannock River in Virginia in 1862. Known as contraband by Union forces, enslaved families sought freedom in Union-held territory.